Individual Usage and Social Impact of Mexico

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The primary goal of this research is to examine the individual usage and societal effects of internet access in Mexico. The purpose of this paper is to analyze key indicators from Network Readiness Index (NRI) and other primary sources to evaluate Mexico's household internet access, individuals using the internet, use of virtual social networks, and internet availability in schools. The outcomes will be used to develop conclusions as well as recommendations for enhancing digital access and utilization in Mexico.

Individuals Using the Internet

The Network Readiness Index (NRI) 2.1.1, *Individuals using the Internet*, represents the percentage of a country's population that spends time on the internet and reflecting the level of digital engagement among individuals. Statistics have been measured according to the percentage of users throughout the population and contributes to evaluating a country's efficiency in integrating technologies into daily life. In the NRI 2022, Mexico achieved a score of 31.11, placing the country's rank at 22nd globally. In the NRI 2023, Mexico faced a slight increase with a score of 34.20 and a lower rank of 24th place (Dutta & Lanvin, 2022; 2023).

Although the NRI data indicates Mexico's strong global standing in individual internet usage, additional statistics reveal that access and participation are influenced by systematic inequalities. Mexico has one of the largest online demographics in Latin America, with access to the internet exceeding 70% of the population in recent years. A key element of internet usage in Mexico is the dependence on mobile connectivity, with almost 88% of users accessing the internet via smartphones. This show both the flexibility and constraints, as mobile networks often serve to address the limitations in fixed broadband infrastructure. According to Slotta, users in Mexico connect online for about seven hours daily; engaging in online activities like

social media, messaging, streaming, and browsing, therefore increasing the countries global rank in individual internet usage. However, rural communities fall behind urban users by approximately 20% in internet access, reflecting major geographic inequalities in infrastructure and service availability. Also, financial inequality remains a major disadvantage, as households with higher incomes are significantly more likely to have reliable internet connection and electronic devices than those in lower income brackets. These inequalities are further increased by differences in digital literacy and degree of education, limiting individuals' ability to utilize the internet for economic and educational progress. While Mexico has shown strong overall usage and engagement, the unequal distribution of access continues to maintain a digital gap that restricts long-term social and economic advancement (Slotta, 2025).

Households with Internet Access

The NRI indicator 1.1.3, *Household with Internet Access*, measures the percentage of households in a country having internet access, indicating the availability and distribution of digital infrastructure ath the residential level. This indicator is measured based on the proportion of internet connected homes and has been used to determine the effectiveness of implementing internet connection into household settings. In the NRI 2023, Mexico's score increased a little to 58.82, and its global ranking dropped to 13th place; reflecting ongoing growth in connectivity despite slight changes in comparison (Dutta & Lanvin, 2022; 2023).

Additional data provides a deeper understanding of home internet access in Mexico, pointing out that national development masks significant regional inequalities. Statista reported that around 66.5% of homes have internet access in 2022, rising to 81.2% in 2023, showing a massive growth in connectivity in a year (Taylor, 2025). However, access varies greatly by area, with wealthier states like Sonora and Baja California Sur reporting access rates of approximately

72% and 76%, whereas lower-income states like Chiapas and Oaxaca have only 13% and 21% of households are connected. A key component contributing to this inequality is the previous control of telecommunications infrastructure by Carlos Slim, whose enterprises América Móvil and Telmex dominated a large proportion of Mexico's landline and mobile services. This level of control restricted competition and retained increased internet pricing, making access less affordable for low-income households. Before 2013, digital infrastructure investments predominantly focused on wealthy urban areas, leading to worsening the digital divide in rural and economically disadvantaged communities. Despite governmental changes, such as the "Mexico Conectado" project and increased market competition, major differences in affordability, infrastructure, and service quality continues to exist nationwide (Ritchie, 2024).

Use of Virtual Social Networks

The NRI indicator 2.1.3 for *Use of Virtual Social Networks* evaluates the degree of individual connection with social media platforms in a country, reflecting trends in digital interaction and communication. This metric assesses the extent of social networking interaction in daily life by analyzing user engagement across various platforms. In the NRI 2022, Mexico earned a score of 73.03 and ranked at 51st globally. For the NRI 2023, the score decreased slightly to 69.11, but the ranking slightly increased to 50th place (Dutta & Lanvin, 2022; 2023).

In 2024, social media usage in Mexico is widespread in everyday digital activity, with around 90.20 million users, representing approximately 70% of the population. Nearly 84% of internet users actively engage with *at least* one social media platform. Platforms including WhatsApp, Facebook, YouTube, and Instagram are among the most commonly used with WhatsApp alone accessed by over 94% of users for communication. Facebook continues to be

one of the major platforms, having over 100 million members, while newer platforms like TikTok have quickly risen to over 60 million users, pointing a rapid shift in favor towards short-form content. Social media also provides other purposes for beyond communication such as entertainment, education, and product research; with over 72% of users accessing sites like Facebook to learn more about products and services. Mexico also ranks among the leading nations for time spent towards social media, with over 90% of internet users consistently engaging in social networking activities (*Social Media in Mexico - 2023 Stats & Platform Trends - OOSGA*, 2023).

Internet in Schools

The NRI indicator 1.1.6 for Internet in Schools focuses on the accessibility of internet resources in educational environments. This indicator evaluates institutional readiness for digital education, rather than the other indicators that assess individual or household access. According to the NRI of 2022, Mexico received a score of 38.88, placing 55th worldwide in this category. In the following year, the score remained at 38.88, although the ranking recorded a slight decline to 57th position. The lack of score improvement indicates an interruption in the expansion of internet connectivity in educational institutions.

Research argues that the lack of infrastructure continues to limit effective internet use in Mexican schools, especially in public and rural regions. For instance, almost 95% of students in private institutions receives internet connection, whereas about 55% in public schools have access; indicating a significant difference in educational schools (Alfaro-Ponce et al., 2023). This disparity reflects underlying systematic challenges, as many educational institutions don't have reliable internet, electricity, and technological resources *essential* for digital learning environments. Alfaro-ponce et al. (2023) suggests that "technology alone in education does not

ensure social equity or inclusion," emphasizing that systemic disparities in internet access can't be addressed by devices alone. The static NRI scores show ongoing challenges in attaining equitable digital access in schools, increasing the divide between privileged and underprivileged educational institutions.

Conclusions and Recommendations

This section covers the conclusions and recommendations based on Mexico's individuals using the internet, households with internet access, use of virtual social networks, and internet access in schools.

Conclusions

1. ***Individuals Using the Internet –*** The use of the internet in Mexico demonstrates a huge increase, leading to the rising integration of digital technologies into everyday life. This increase is unfair and rural and low-income communities persistently encounter barriers in access and digital literacy. Meaning that although overall engagement is high, the positive effects of internet usage are not equally distributed.
2. ***Households with Internet Access –*** Household internet access in Mexico has steadily risen, suggesting advancements towards national connectivity and digital infrastructures. Regardless of this advancement, access remains to be severely disproportionate across states, with rural and low-income areas greatly falling behind. This implies that the growth in connectivity does not usually result in equitable access for all households.
3. ***Use of Virtual Social Networks –*** Social media has become an essential part of daily living in Mexico, influencing how people communicate, access information, and engaging in various online activities. The small decrease in performance shows that digital consumption may be reaching an oversaturation point rather than decreasing in importance. Yet social networks continue to be a major

influence in Mexico's digital culture, with their role stabilizing as adoption develops.

4. ***Internet in Schools –*** In contrast to other indicators of digital access, internet connectivity in schools has mostly stayed static, indicating an absence in educational infrastructure development. This lack of progress exposes persistent inequalities between well-funded schools and those under-funded in basic technology support. In the absence of technological improvements, numerous students will continue to face barriers in digital learning opportunities.

Recommendations

1. ***Individuals Using the Internet***

   The Mexican government needs to expand affordable internet accessibility in rural and underdeveloped regions to alleviate inequalities in individual use. It'll also be beneficial in investing in digital literacy programs; since it would help citizens utilize internet resources more effectively for educational and financial opportunities.

2. ***Households with Internet Access***

   There needs to be more funding to invest in broadband infrastructure, especially in rural regions where access is still limited. Policies that promote competition among service providers to avoid a monopoly market, enforce reduced costs, and improve service quality for Mexican households.

3. ***Use of Virtual Social Networks***

   Instead of focusing only on access, attention should also be placed on the usage of social media throughout Mexico. Expanding programs that encourage educational and business use for social platforms could help a transition towards more positive outcomes and lasting benefits.

4. ***Internet in Schools***

   Addressing inequalities in educational internet access requires prioritizing underprivileged rural and public institutions where the digital infrastructure continues to remain limited. Local government and community development programs can reduce the divide by expanding digital training for teachers to further support integrating technology in classrooms.

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